

THE NEW HIRE SAFETY ONBOARDING CHECKLIST

Your Day 1 to Day 30 Guide to Safe, Confident New Hires

The early weeks in a new job can be a higher-risk period, particularly while workers are learning unfamiliar tasks, equipment, hazards, and procedures.

A structured onboarding process can help employers address those risks and reinforce safe work practices. New hires are absorbing new equipment, new processes, and new people all at once, and the learning curve is exactly where injuries like to hide.

This checklist breaks the onboarding window into manageable milestones so nothing critical slips through the cracks, whether you're welcoming a warehouse crew, a retail team, or a construction hire.



Note: This checklist is a general planning tool and is not a complete statement of OSHA requirements. Requirements vary by industry, task, hazard, employee role, and OSHA State Plan.



01

DAY ONE: FIRST IMPRESSIONS AND FIRST DEFENSES

☐	Welcome and introduce the new hire to their direct supervisor and team.
☐	Conduct facility or site hazard orientation (walk the floor, point out hot zones, hazard signage, and restricted areas).
☐	Review and document emergency procedures (evacuation routes, muster points, fire extinguisher locations, incident reporting process).
☐	Issue required PPE and confirm proper fit (gloves, eye protection, hearing protection, footwear, etc.).
☐	Provide hazard-appropriate PPE, training, and fit confirmation before covered work. Complete required medical evaluation and fit testing before required respirator use.
☐	Assign a buddy or mentor for the onboarding period.
☐	Provide emergency contact information and confirm the new hire knows who to call and how.
☐	Share the location of first aid kits, eyewash stations, and safety data sheets.

02

WEEK ONE: BUILDING THE HABITS

☐	Complete required equipment training before independent use (machinery, tools, vehicles, or POS systems as applicable).
☐	Provide role-appropriate lockout/tagout training, if applicable.
☐	Confirm understanding of hazard communication (GHS labels, chemical storage, SDS access).
☐	Shadow buddy/mentor through at least one full shift.
☐	Conduct a first check-in: ask what's confusing, what feels unsafe, and what training gaps have surfaced.
☐	Verify PPE is being worn correctly and consistently.
☐	Log completion of any required compliance training (OSHA-specific or role-specific).

03

30-DAY MARK: MAKING IT STICK

☐	Conduct a formal 30-day safety check-in with supervisor and mentor present.
☐	Reassess PPE fit and condition as the new hire settles into daily tasks.
☐	Confirm the new hire can independently execute emergency procedures without prompting and review any near-misses, incidents, or close calls from the first month.
☐	Identify additional training needs based on observed performance.
☐	Formally close out the mentor/buddy assignment or transition to ongoing peer support and document checklist completion and required training records.